

Activating Legacies of Freedom to Transform Economies of Prestige in Academia and Ourselves

Javiela Evangelista

ABSTRACT: Liberation literacies (Ellis; Lyiscott, “Three Ways”) and antiracist praxis (García Peña; Chavez) help us to find power in technologies that harness legacies of freedom, in communion with resistance, joy, and fortitude. I channel this hope into action in our classrooms through student derived (or guided) measures in order to activate the power of liberation within ourselves, our legacies, and communities. In doing so, we aim to transform damaging economies of prestige, based in exclusion and hierarchy that often undergird academia (Hartman). One of the goals is to challenge such hierarchies by creating and facilitating spaces for students to be entirely themselves and to speak, write, and learn in ways that tap into the power of legacies of freedom. Student contributions in an undergraduate course, The Heritage of Imperialism at New York City College of Technology, and Black Diasporic Visions: (De) Constructing Modes of Power, a graduate course at the CUNY Graduate Center, as well as a brief overview of work under the Futures Initiative (FI) and Transformative Learning in the Humanities (TLH), are featured to support the claim that CUNY is a legacy of freedom itself. Pseudonyms are employed to protect research participants and collaborators.

KEYWORDS: antiracist praxis; CUNY; economies of prestige; legacies of freedom; liberation literacies

“There is no separation between life and writing. No topic is too trivial”—Gloria Anzaldúa

LEGACIES OF FREEDOM

Legacies of freedom draw from the cultivation of spaces undefined by or resistive of damaging hierarchies, and those who have and continue to fight against structural oppression, those who fight against accumulation by dispossession, those who make something from nothing (or what appears to be) in the face of dispossession. The legacies may be of the past or unfolding in the present and future. They live in defiance of time.

The Heritage of Imperialism is an interdisciplinary undergraduate course that is either team taught across disciplines or requires a multitude of guest lecturers across specializations. By facilitating student engagement with

imperialism around a range of fields (media, hospitality, technology, biology, history, and mathematics for example), we actively work to deconstruct the oppressive and implicit biases that facilitate imperialism, even as they exist within ourselves and our professions as participants of the course.

We discuss how imperialism is not only historical, but current in continuity with the past. We rethink the spaces that imperialism may inhabit beyond the physical territories impacted by imperialism, how it may include our minds and bodies. We consider imperialism as a global entity that may also reverberate beyond the global and in the local. We also not only interrogate imperialism as top-down and imposed upon, but also both resisted and absorbed, and hence often not quite far away. We reconceptualize imperialism across time, space, place and self-understanding.

How Europe Underdeveloped Africa by Walter Rodney is one of the first reads in the The Heritage of Imperialism course in any given semester. It remains a staple because it lays solid ground to understand the centrality of modern capitalism, one of many themes that we explore during the semester together. As class begins, we settle in and think through questions about the material in different media formats (critical essay, lyrics, film, ethnography, ceramics) and then jot down our ideas with supporting evidence or inspiration. Page numbers, timestamps, photos, and other forms of documentation are needed to take the reader down the path envisioned. We then pair up, and talk about our thoughts, and what we're writing. Afterwards, we share one another's perspective, paying attention to the synergies and the moments when there are different ways of approaching it.

In an attempt to break down the walls of our classroom and connect with one another and our community, one of the culminating class assignments, students share a copy of a text from our course that was impactful with someone outside of the class (a family member, friend, colleague, someone met while commuting, or visiting another campus). Then they write about

Javiela Evangelista is an Assistant Professor in the African American Studies Department at New York City College of Technology, CUNY. A public anthropologist, her participatory research counters inequalities at the intersections of citizenship and racialization in the Caribbean and the African Diaspora. She develops courses and open educational resources including *The Heritage of Imperialism* and earned her PhD in Anthropology from the Graduate Center, CUNY, and her MA from Columbia University's Institute for Research in African American Studies.

why they chose that particular person and text and what evolved from the exchange. Any “why” that is thoughtful and open ended, giving pathways of exploration and growth, is welcome. Then, we ask students to develop a final written reflection inspired by the exchange (in collaboration with those who were a part of it, when possible) guided by questions such as: What did you learn from this exchange in our expanded community classroom? Was anything expected or surprising? Are there ways in which you would expand this experience or assignment?

We sat in a circle on our last day of class for presentations for the culminating reflection and a student named Beltrice shared with us,

Here I was, thinking I was going to teach my Mom something. But her earliest memories of how money worked in the world, best practices with her own money, financial literacy, came from her father’s teachings of Walter Rodney.

At first glance, Beltrice’s commentary on her writing about the heritage of Rodney in her family, essentially about something her mama said, may seem negligible, but there is mountainous power here.

Beltrice went on,

Papa used to talk to Mom about Rodney, the multiple attempts to connect the African diaspora and the need to help change the experience of each generation by saving, pursuing education, organizing labor. I was surprised Mom not only knew about *How Europe Underdeveloped Africa*, but also about Rodney’s other work and life. She told me about his book, *Groundings with my Brothers*.

A while ago, Dr. Lorgia García Peña, founding faculty member of Freedom University¹ in Georgia and an illuminating force like Gloria Anzaldúa, shared with me that she met with women in her family circle once a month to discuss a reading from her course syllabi. Particularly elders who have lived through some of the historical material, who have life experience that goes beyond the text, and who bring an invaluable richness that one professor or even one hundred members of one lecture class cannot hold. There is critical value in celebrating the continuity of our community’s knowledge and resistance within the university (García Peña).

Legacies of Freedom may invite co-teaching across disciplines and ranks, student-centered work, mutually beneficial communal and public work. They create space for metacognition and questioning (the whom,

where, how, what) not only of the material, but of our relationship to it, citing those who have been unjustly marginalized, honoring the activism and love that led to the emergence of departments like mine. These are models that give us possibilities, while troubling the values at hand, challenging the depository banking system that is foundational in education.

Legacies of freedom may be ancestral, or connected to racial or ethnic heritage, but they don't have to be. In my classes, offered in the African American Studies department at New York City College of Technology, City University of New York, legacies of freedom draw from the African Diaspora, but also a range of experiences at the intersection of many in the diaspora and beyond, including the working class, LGBTQIA+, and global anti-colonial and anti-imperial organizing. My personal experience of activating legacies of freedom is grounded in (Black) liberation literacies (Ellis; Lyiscott, "Three Ways"), antiracist praxis (García Peña; Chavez), Indigenous praxis (Long Soldier; Trask) and fugitive pedagogies (Givens). However, powerful conjurings may come from acknowledging, mourning, celebrating, and organizing around the connections that exist between and that cover and protect many freedom legacies—existing despite and along vast borders and eras.

UNDOING ECONOMIES OF PRESTIGE

Inequities in the field of higher education must be examined in order to enact transformations in pedagogy and our classrooms. At its inception, higher education was aligned with the industrial workforce, which led to the development of the credit hour system and many of the current structures of academe (Davidson and Katopodis). Furthermore, "only 0.4 percent of all students in our universities in the United States attend the Ivies, but most books and articles written about higher education and pedagogy seem to assume students from those universities" and a great number of professors have attended Research One universities (Davidson and Katopodis). Essentially, since colleges and universities were established based on maintaining "hierarchy, ranking, and selectivity," how may we best approach changing university value systems (Davidson and Katopodis)? According to Stacy Hartman, previous Director of the Publics Lab at the CUNY Graduate Center², "prestige economies are based in exclusion." Hartman adds, "the universities that are ranked the highest are the ones that exclude the most people. . . and that's how we define excellence in the academy. . . exclusion is the ultimate metric of success." Although university rankings may be changing (Saul and Hartocollis), by highlighting the values of our almost sixty-year-old

university ranking system (Wilbers), the deeply embedded nature of value systems based in exclusion within academia is evident.

However, interventions may be made by altering systems of prestige. Working-class public university classrooms like at CUNY can be a powerful place to unlearn, resist, and reapply energies away from this system of prestige. If academics put student exploration of legacies of freedom front and center and weave them into our rubrics, we can shift the center by encouraging students to value what is already within ourselves and our communities, although not at the center of academe. For example, we can foster conversation on course material with people beyond the class roster—those whom we love, those here and those no longer in the physical form, those whom we connect with in passing (which many New Yorkers who commute may appreciate). Ultimately, we can learn from those who are often outside of academia or from geographic regions not prioritized in academia—conversations which are critical to reversing these systems of academic exclusivity. Such processes can usher in the potential to activate legacies of freedom and alter what is valued in society.

When we reverse the logic of individualized academic prestige to focus on our majority working-class learning communities, another set of communal experiences reveal themselves as worthy of focus and care. In class, we have discovered that communal pedagogies (and, ultimately, rituals) draw our attention to critical questions that may help us to rethink and undo economies of prestige. What legacies of freedom may we use to most clearly care for and conjure power for our students, as well as others in their lives? With whom? Where? How? It solidifies connection to the material, furthers growth, and is an act of metacognition: getting one thinking about their own thoughts. As a practice, it is important to provide credit, citations, for *where* these conversations and activations may take place, for example. At the height of the pandemic, many of us held classroom discussions by way of Zoom, sitting at our kitchen counters as family members walked back and forth, with pictures of beloveds on the wall, children's art or magnets on the fridge in the background, sometimes a blank wall with shadows drifting. These are the spaces where conjurings (that we may or may not even be attuned to) often occur. Likewise, for in-person courses, spaces outside of the walls of academia (home, memory, subway, feet on soil) can remain welcome and present in our classrooms.

We do not always need to reach far in order to connect with the public. May we help facilitate the classroom as an extension of one's living room, or literally invite elders in? May we think about the range of sources (not

just people, but places) that make up legacies of freedom and include them in our citations? Even if some of our time is spent in the classroom, aren't we too a part of this public?

Prestige exclusions cause all involved to lose out on the profound kinds of learning and analysis that we experienced with Beltrice, and that African diasporic and global anti-oppression methods and materials create. During any given semester, in reference to the topics we address within African American Studies, a student may comment, "I wish I had learned about these things before coming to college!" Prioritizing legacies of freedom in our pedagogy offers a fast intervention, an immediate potential opening that is mutually beneficial for all involved—pending the longer-term, bureaucratically-complex goals such as curriculum change.

Freedom legacies must also be cultivated in the context of workplace inequalities. We often work within institutions where the majority of the working force is underpaid and without benefits. Many have heavy course loads, are not paid over holidays, and have little job security. However, it is often not a part of our students' education to know about the ways in which the disparities live. Many students are unaware of unequal treatment of full-time instructors and adjunct lecturers. How may such conversations also nourish a legacy of freedom for many of us as instructors woven into the fabric of institutions of higher education? How can we expand these conversations out into the world, at a juncture when people are coordinating economic blackouts or boycotts against corporations that have rolled back support of their communities? We are seeing how efforts to direct one's money toward small businesses instead, for example, is connected to a critique of the capitalist structure that Beltrice's family introduced her to by reading Rodney. Tapping into legacies of freedom may not only alter economies of prestige in academia but can inspire tangible change in the world.

PRAXIS AT CITY UNIVERSITY OF NEW YORK (CUNY)

Freedom legacy work is also embedded in the bones, the very purpose of the Futures Initiative at The Graduate Center, City University of New York (CUNY)—a program that supports course creation across disciplines, ranks, and CUNY campuses, and culminates in a public project. As a Futures Initiative Fellow, I developed and co-taught the course *Black Diasporic Visions (De) Constructing Modes of Power* with Dr. Carla Shedd, who was Associate Professor of Urban Education and Sociology at Graduate Center, CUNY at the time. Developing the course together as scholars in different fields, campuses,

and ranks enabled a nourishing collaboration that required the reworking of typical hierarchies. We extended the call to rethink the structure of the classroom with a collaborative student-faculty course syllabus and weekly student presentations (Evangelista and Shedd). In the class, graduate students came from a range of disciplines studying education, race, carceral justice, and more. We invited scholars, activists, and artists within CUNY, as well as from outside (dubbed “village visitors”), who poured their expertise and community-engaged work into our sessions.³

Our final course project was a public open educational resource, *Black Diasporic Visions: (De) Constructing Modes of Power, Reflections and Resources*, available on the CUNY digital publishing platform *Manifold* (Adler, Angela, Chevalier, Brathwaite, Brito, Enobabor, Evangelista, Mina, Poe, Shedd, Reece Washington, Welch-Scott, and Barrales). Rather than a final project presented within a classroom or handed to the professor who will be the only one to see it, the site features the students’ hopes, visions, and recommendations toward liberatory possibilities—including op-ed abstracts from articles that students submitted to various outlets—aiming to break down the walls of the classroom and have discussion with a wider audience. The collective publication has been well received and featured in a range of outlets (Butler).

I love visioning—it is the balm that keeps my Black body here on this earth. I think perhaps one of the greatest forms of oppression we can experience as a people is the inability to vision a new way forward.—Black Diasporic Visions Graduate Student

For this multimodal site, we invited user engagement “to break down false divides between theory and praxis,” and outlined terms of collective use to create an intentional safe space. The students’ cumulative public publication on the site fostered “collaboration and work beyond traditional notions of curation” and is a “model of emerging scholar mentoring and training that centers the knowledge and experiences students bring into the classroom to develop community-oriented praxis” (Butler). Students enhanced the definitions of known keywords with an annotated bibliography on terms each chose—such as anti-Blackness, Black reproductive futurity, surveillance, and *malcriada*⁴—which the graduate students grounded in existing research. They then poured in their expertise, expanding references and possibilities in galactic ways beyond the original imaginations of the course. Some work gave birth to new terms likely to change the scope of legacies of freedom, like *blackspotting*, a term proposed “to address the ongoing, deliberate attempts

to reinsert Blackness, Black bodies, lives, thought and presence, in spaces where they have been intentionally erased and obscured” (Poe). There was also a powerful open letter to a niece, breaking down barriers concerning the audience of our academic work (Angela). Tarot card offerings and music with deep historical and current references by Jamila Woods, all curated by the students in this student directed course.

During one of our early sessions, one of the students in *Black Diasporic Visions* insisted with the utmost enthusiasm that we add the work of JJJJ-Jerome Ellis, “a self identified blk disabled animal, stutterer, and artist” (Cole) who implores us to reconsider his dysfluency (stutter) as a call for patience, a space where archangels may sing. “Of himself, he says, ‘I have an ongoing practice of spelling my name JJJJJerome Ellis in certain circumstances. I do this because the word I stutter on most frequently is my name. You can choose which spelling you prefer” (Cole). Through a range of mediums, Ellis “researches relationships among blackness, disabled speech, divinity, nature, sound, and time” (Cole). Ellis prompts powerful conversations about deconstructing how we approach and hear one another, and how we approach and hear ourselves.

Given the many openings it gifted us in *Black Diasporic Visions* at the Graduate Center, I added Ellis’ work to an undergraduate course at City Tech, and one of the students, James, shared that he too experiences disfluency and posttraumatic stress. He ended up featuring Ellis as a part of his final presentation. A requirement is that the presentation is publicly engaged, with an open invitation and located at times in public squares and streets close to campus. The student noted that he had never come across a theorist who aptly and positively spoke to the possibilities in the pauses that he too lives with. Here a student (and the concept of a student-guided syllabus) in a graduate-level course opened up portals for undergraduates at another CUNY campus. What James initially felt was trivial in academe (beyond the technicalities of his accommodations) he then connected to theory and his own writing, as directed by other (graduate) students.

The Andrew W. Mellon Foundation’s Transformative Learning in the Humanities Initiative, (or TLH *Movement*, as one of the co-Directors, Dr. Shelley Eversley, affectionately calls it) provides further insight into how freedom legacies are carved out and exchanged at CUNY. As a TLH Faculty Fellow, then as a Pedagogy Co-Leader, I worked with the TLH Movement directors to coordinate semester-long workshops addressing four goals central to TLH’s mission: 1) Promote equitable, creative, student-centered pedagogical research and methods designed for the rich diversity of CUNY students; 2) Support greater institutional recognition for the importance of

teaching; 3) Advance the role of an urgent and indispensable humanities for the future of CUNY students and a more just and equitable society; and 4) Practice diversity as crucial to learning within and beyond the classroom.

Students and teachers are partners, jointly responsible for knowledge creation.—Felicia Rose Chavez

One of the many strengths of TLH was how it acknowledged, credited, celebrated, and built upon previous work generations- and centuries-long. In preparation for the workshops we read Gloria Anzaldúa and the *Lost and Found: The CUNY Poetics Document Initiative* collection of CUNY teaching archives featuring Adrienne Rich, June Jordan, Audre Lorde, and Toni Cade Bambara. Workshops with Felicia Rose Chavez, Jamilia Lyiscott, and Jessie Stommel enabled hands-on explorations of antiracist writing, liberation literacies, and ungrading to get away from problematic hierarchies embedded in academia, alongside other selections from a range of disciplines, localities, and timeframes. When she referenced Rodney, Beltrice was presenting her own public project—engaging with family around a course reading—which resulted from the TLH Movement.

The other co-Director of TLH at the time, Cathy Davidson, often opened or closed our meetings with an “entry” or “exit ticket,” a light and open question related to pedagogy, inviting participation and expanded thinking: “Our students are in our classes for a reason. Have you discussed their ‘why’ with them? And what is *your* ‘why’? Why do you teach?”

These questions took my memory back. Under flags from all over the world at my mothers international school, for over 40 years she coordinated a curriculum celebrating the vastness of the Americas (beyond “America” as the North) and the overshadowed contributions of Black and Indigenous communities. My memory took me to a diligently working nine-year-old me, doing homework in the back row of free citizenship classes taught in the evenings by Mom, a third grade Spanish immersion teacher by day. I could vividly see Mom after the sessions, chatting with and hugging her students, lots of empanadas shared and tender moments about proud graduations, or a mothers passing that went far beyond the citizenship curriculum. I saw and felt deeply that “justice is what love looks like in public.” And also that a good education and a community that connects learners to the world and themselves simultaneously, and us with each other, toward the embodiment of concepts like world making, and self-sufficiency, far beyond the conceptual level, was love.

Intention was embedded in the relationships, structures, and processes of our work at TLH. In a rare opportunity to collaborate and synergize across CUNY campuses, each fellow adopted public projects, provided metro cards, and changed their syllabi to address students with care and incorporate their perspectives. The fellowship culminated in a final public project where fellows collaborated with colleagues across the university to develop an open public conversation or piece. We invited academics and activists from Puerto Rico, Philippines, and Dominican Republic to strategize about pedagogy globally for an “Imperialism, Education, and Resistance” faculty final project.

What do we really think we can learn from them?—*Adrienne Rich*
(*Part I, 16*)

When Adrienne Rich, City College professor, feminist, and pedagogical muse, asked instructors—during the late 1960s Black and Puerto Rican students-led upheavals at City College that precipitated Open Admissions at CUNY—what they really think they can learn from their students, we are reminded here that it is not just about what instructors may learn from students as individuals. With each student and instructor (with all of us in academia) comes a community and lineages which we can learn from, even if we are not directly connected to them. In my classes, there is an invitation to grace all of us with the linguistics celebration of your mama, papa, and cousin’s knowledge, precious foresight, and vision. Nothing is too trivial. The way you speak, who you love and learn from, and where all that is sacred, is a welcome offering, received, valued, and reciprocated that may enrich our engagement with one another if the space is provided. In addition to our calls to cite Black women (Smith et al.), this is an invitation to cite ancestors, cite mamas, cite abuelas, cite Indigenous knowledge, cite other students, cite yourself, cite the pause.

In this current moment when Black Studies, Ethnic and Gender Studies are being erased from school curricula by the current administration, it is dangerous to see liberatory praxis as a fad or something to be added in and taken away at a moment’s notice. By historicizing antiracist pedagogy with research grounded in members of our families and communities who may be unpublished at the crossroads of those who are—Anzaldúa, hooks, and the work of Black, Latinx, and Jewish Feminists, particularly at CUNY (Bambara, Jordan, Lorde, Rich)—let us call attention to the difference between pedagogy that comes from a long history with practices built into legacies of freedom (CUNY Digital History Archive), as opposed to “progressive” pedagogies that

often seem to emerge from thin air, ungrounded.

Within this historically grounded and forward-looking framework of legacies of freedom, we counter the white supremacy that exists in programs that enforce limited, often monolingual assumptions, writing systems, and pedagogies. Grounded references to these long-standing decolonial antiracist pedagogies help us to build upon and create long-standing decolonial antiracist communities in the university and beyond.

A CALL TO ACTIVATE FREEDOM LEGACIES TOGETHER

Liberation Literacy theorist Jamila Lyiscott analyzes the internal struggle to edit and stifle the power of language in the classroom, as some languages are not equally valued in academia or a part of the prestige economies in this space. Let us relish in the power, the flow, and the structure in the spoken words of patois Kreyol, and in this case, African American English (Rickford). Lyiscott bellows, “Even our language has rules. . . never does the word mad go before a present participle” (“Three Ways”). She croons, “Sometimes I fight back two tongues, while I use the other one in the classroom, and when mistakenly I mix them up, I feel like I’m cooking in the bathroom,” noting her discomfort, her awareness of her pull to exclude central parts of herself, all while in a context where she is being evaluated (Lyiscott, “Three Ways”). This highlights the importance and presence of home-spaces outside of the classroom, in relation to experiences in the classroom. She grounds the historicity of this experience in inequity, and notes that language may be a portal. Similarly, across our CUNY experiences, as a result of a graduate student’s exploration of legacies of freedom, Ellis’s theory of fluency transformed the undergraduate student David’s relationship with his own speech.

A central part of transforming economies of prestige in academia includes creating spaces for students to be entirely themselves, and to speak and write in ways that tap into powers that may not be centrally incorporated in the curriculum. Let us foster the space to include our why, who, where, how, and what of liberatory practice as instructors in student-directed ways that invites in the many parts of who students are and the world beyond the class. This may include the way words are spoken at home, whether locally or abroad, in the past, present, or future, with pauses in speech, or wordless expressions—like a nod that speaks volumes.

I find myself telling my students that I love them now, more than ever. All of my loved ones, really. I’ve been reaching out more regularly, making calls to my mother and sending texts to cousins. I am not breaking new

ground here. This love in and of itself is a freedom legacy. Why else would Harriet go back so many times? What drove the Black Panthers to start the Free Breakfast Program? Why did the New York Young Lords fight to establish a Patient's Bill of Rights? How did we even come to have an African American Studies Department at New York City College of Technology, CUNY from which I teach? Students organized and demanded Ethnic Studies and African American Studies, precisely because they loved their communities, loved their history, loved the idea of creating new futures. Right now, during a time when democracy is in peril and assaults on personhood and dignity are commonplace, saying and hearing words of love, while also creating the space for legacies of freedom and shifting economies of prestige, within our classrooms, in community with one another, provides us with firm ground to stand on, a powerful tool.

Returning to where we began here with Beltrice's unearthing of her mother's theoretical upbringing brings us to Felicia Rose Chavez framing the mothering of students as a decolonial act, again of what else if not love: "As a professor of color I'd 'mothered' my writers from the jump, taking on extra, invisible labor, serving as a mentor. . . A good part of my day was dedicated to listening." Despite the overextension and lack of institutional support for professors of color, another facet of the damaging economies of prestige, Chavez notes why it is important for her to love and listen to students. As a result, she questions, "Why must listening be antithetical when we know they are symbiotic? Why does emotional care undermine intellectual growth in my colleagues' minds?" (Chavez).

We are calling for the support of more spaces where students, all of us, are heard in fullness, without stifling aspects of self, and that welcome community contributions that are anti-oppressive and liberatory—spaces where faculty can shift from what "Brazilian educator and philosopher Paulo Freire calls 'banking systems of education' in which students are the depositories and the teacher is the depositor" (Chavez). These banking systems, currently most benefit privileged white males who can see themselves in their instructors, thus enabling them to attach to psychic wages of whiteness (Du Bois; Chavez). Instead we move toward "an act of love and humility that subverts the teacher's authority and elevates the students to critical co-investigators" (Chavez 50). This is what we may call a "humanist approach, according to Freire, 'imbued with a profound trust in people and their creative power'" (Chavez 52).

To conclude, legacies of freedom that build upon liberation literacies (Ellis; Lyiscott) and antiracist praxis (García Peña; Chavez) may invite

co-teaching across disciplines and ranks, student centered work that can carry greater importance than letter grades, can offer opportunities for communal and public work that builds beyond the course, and can create space for metacognition and questioning with permission for the self and community to enter—citing those who have been unjustly marginalized, and critically celebrating (and thus living) the activism and love that led to the emergence of departments like African American and Ethnic Studies, Gender and Sexuality Studies, and Disability Studies in our pedagogical work.

Much like Ellis, I contend here that activating legacies of freedom may shift values from economies of prestige and instead require pause and patience for openings. Recognizing, celebrating, and creating space for these nutrients in our classroom environment, in a manner that is not extractive or transactional, has greater potential to enrich the experience for all. As such, most significantly, we can activate legacies of freedom and transformation, not only in our classrooms, but in the greater spaces in which we learn, thrive, and love, which can include academic institutions at large, home, and our greater communities.

This is an invitation: a call to ground and activate these freedom legacies as tools and technologies in our classrooms as an act of love. The most powerful aspect of these legacies of freedom is that they are immortal, indestructible. No person, no thing, no solitary confinement, no deportation, no political administration can take away legacies of freedom or our ability to tap into them, or our entitlement to walk the paths we pave. But we must choose to use them, archive them, build upon them.

Notes

1. Freedom University is an award-winning human rights organization and modern-day freedom school for undocumented students banned from equal access to higher education in Georgia. Freedom University provides tuition-free college preparation classes, college and scholarship application assistance, mental health and legal support, and social movement leadership development for undocumented students. For more information, see <https://www.freedom-university.org/history>
2. From 2018-2023 The Publics Lab provided support for the Mellon Humanities Public Fellows, sponsored events, grants, and fellowships related to public scholarship, and served as a resource for faculty and students interested in making their work more public. For more information, see <https://publicslab.gc.cuny.edu/>.

3. Standing on the shoulder of village visitors, Zee Dempster, Osagyefou Sekou, Brandye Lee, Stacy Hartman, Camille Fair, Josef Sorret, Simin Farkhondeh, and Emanuel Admassu.
4. A poorly raised young woman.

Works Cited

- Adler, Josh, Rosa Angela, Wendy Barrales, Darializa Avila Chevalier, Brittany Brathwaite, J. Michell Brito, O. D. Enobabor, Javiela Evangelista, Ruben Mina, Janelle Poe, Carla Shedd, Kayla Reece, Ashleigh Washington, and Crystal Welch-Scott. "Black Diasporic Visions: (De)Constructing Modes of Power, Reflections and Resources." *Manifold*, 2022, <https://cuny.manifoldapp.org/projects/black-diasporic-visions-de-constructing-modes-of-power>.
- Anzaldúa, Gloria. "Speaking In Tongues: A Letter To 3rd World Women Writers." *Words In Our Pockets: The Feminist Writers' Guild Handbook*, edited by Celeste West, Bootlegger, 1980.
- Bambara, Toni Cade. "Realizing the Dream of a Black University" & Other Writings (Parts I & II). Co-edited by Makeba Lavan and Conor Tomás Reed. *Lost & Found: The CUNY Poetics Document Initiative, Series 7*, The Center for the Humanities, Graduate Center of the City University of New York, 2017.
- Blum, Susan D. *Why Grading Undermines Students (and What to Do Instead)*. West Virginia University Press, 2020.
- Butler, Maia. "Review of 'Black Diasporic Visions: (De)Constructing Modes of Power, Reflections and Resources.'" *Reviews in Digital Humanities*, vol. 5, no. 11, Nov. 2024. <https://doi.org/10.21428/3e88f64f.efbd1954>
- Chavez, Felicia Rose. *The Anti-Racist Writing Workshop: How to Decolonize the Creative Classroom*. Haymarket Books, 2021.
- Cole, Sean. "Time Bandit." *This American Life*, featuring JJJJJJerome Ellis, WBEZ, 7 Aug. 2020.
- CUNY Digital History Archive, n.d., <https://cdha.cuny.edu/>.
- Curiel, Ochy, Manuela Borzone, and Alexander Ponomareff. "Rethinking Radical Anti-Racist Feminist Politics in a Global Neoliberal Context." *Meridians*, vol. 14, no. 2, 2016, pp. 46–55.
- Davidson, Cathy N., and Christina Katopodis. *The New College Classroom*. Harvard University Press, 2022.
- Du Bois, W. E. B. *Black Reconstruction: An Essay Toward a History of the Part Which Black Folk Played in the Attempt to Reconstruct Democracy in America, 1860-1880*. Harcourt Brace & Company, 1935.

- Ellis, JJJJerome. "The Clearing: Music, Dysfluency, Blackness and Time." *Journal of Interdisciplinary Voice Studies*, vol. 5, no. 2, 1 Dec. 2020, pp. 215–233.
- English, James F. *The Economy of Prestige: Prizes, Awards, and the Circulation of Cultural Value*. Harvard University Press, 2005.
- Espinoza Miñoso, Yuderkis. "Etnocentrismo y Colonialidad en los Feminismos Latinoamericanos: Complicidades y Consolidación de las Hegemonías Feministas en el Espacio Transnacional." *Revista Venezolana de Estudios de la Mujer*, vol. 14, no. 33, Julio/Diciembre 2009, pp. 37–54.
- Evangelista, Javiela, and Carla Shedd. "Black Diasporic Visions: (De)Constructing Modes of Power, IDS 81680, WSCP 81000, & UED 71200" [Syllabus]. Spring 2022.
- García Peña, Lorgia. *Community as Rebellion: A Syllabus for Surviving Academia as a Woman of Color*. Haymarket Books, 2022.
- Givens, Jarvis. *Fugitive Pedagogy: Carter G. Woodson and the Art of Black Teaching*. Harvard University Press, 2021.
- Hartman, Stacy. "Graduate Education at Work in the World", *Futures Initiative Conference*, CUNY Graduate Center, 2020.
- hooks, bell. *Teaching to Transgress: Education as the Practice of Freedom*, Routledge, 1994.
- Inoue, Asao B. "Problematizing Grading and the White Habitus of the Writing Classroom," in *Labor-Based Grading Contracts: Building Equity and Inclusion in the Compassionate Writing Classroom*. The WAC Clearinghouse and UP of Colorado, 2019, pp. 21–48.
- . Chair's Address at CCC Conference. 4 Apr. 2019. *National Council of Teachers of English YouTube Channel*.
- Jordan, June. "Life Studies," 1966–1976. Co-edited by Conor Tomás Reed and Talia Shalev. *Lost & Found: The CUNY Poetics Document Initiative, Series 7*, The Center for the Humanities, Graduate Center of the City University of New York, 2017.
- Long Soldier, Layli. *Whereas*. Graywolf Press, 2017.
- Lorde, Audre. "I teach myself in outline," *Notes, Journals, Syllabi, & an Excerpt from Deotha*. Co-edited by Miriam Atkin and Iemanjá Brown. *Lost & Found: The CUNY Poetics Document Initiative, Series 7*, The Center for the Humanities, Graduate Center of the City University of New York, 2017.
- Lyiscott, Jamila. *Black Appetite, White Food: Issues of Race, Voice, and Justice Within and Beyond the Classroom*. Routledge, 2019.
- . "Three Ways to Speak English." *TED Talks*, 2014.

- Rich, Adrienne. *"What we are a part of": Teaching at CUNY, 1968-1974 (Parts I-II)*. Co-edited by Iemanjá Brown, Stefania Heim, erica kaufman, Kristin Moriah, Conor Tomás Reed, Talia Shalev, Wendy Tronrud, and Ammiel Alcalay. *Lost & Found: The CUNY Poetics Document Initiative, Series 4* (The Center for the Humanities, Graduate Center of the City University of New York, 2014).
- Rickford, Russell J. *We Are an African People: Independent Education, Black Power, and the Radical Imagination*. Oxford University Press, 2016.
- Rodney, Walter. *How Europe Underdeveloped Africa*. Bogle-L'Ouverture Publications, 1972.
- Saul, Stephanie and Anemona Hartocollis. "Columbia University Drops Out of U.S. News Rankings for Undergraduate Schools." *New York Times*, 6 Jun. 2023.
- Saunders, Tanya L. *Cuban Underground Hip Hop: Black Thoughts, Black Revolution, Black Modernity*. University of Texas Press, 2015.
- Smith, Christen A., Erica L. Williams, Imani A. Wadud, Whitney N. L. Pirtle, and the Cite Black Women Collective. "Cite Black Women: A Critical Praxis (A Statement)." *Feminist Anthropology*, vol. 2, no. 1, 2021, pp. 10–17.
- Stommel, Jesse. "Ungrading and Alternative Assessment." Workshop for Transformative Learning in the Humanities, City University of New York and Andrew W. Mellon Foundation, 21 Mar. 2022.
- Robles, Rojo. "Imperialism, Education, and Resistance: Experiences from Puerto Rico, the Philippines, and the Dominican Republic." Transformative Learning in the Humanities, 7 Dec. 2021, <https://transform.commonsgc.cuny.edu/2021/12/07/imperialism-education-and-resistance-experiences-from-puerto-rico-the-philippines-and-the-dominican-republic/>.
- Trask, Haunani-Kay. *From a Native Daughter: Colonialism and Sovereignty in Hawai'i* (Revised ed.). University of Hawai'i Press, 1999.
- Wilbers, Stefan, and Jelena Brankovic. "The Emergence of University Rankings: A Historical-Sociological Account." *Higher Education*, vol. 86, no. 4, 2023, pp. 733–750.
- Williams, Bianca. "Black Feminist Politic of Teaching & Organizing with Emotion." Franklin Humanities Institute, 20 Mar. 2017.